Teaching Statement

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This teaching statement covers my teaching philosophy, the courses I've taught at Pratt, mentoring and advising, and future plans.

Philosophy

The values and techniques described in my teaching philosophy draw from my graduate school training in literary studies and queer studies and my early teaching experience as a writing instructor for 6 years. I am a strong proponent of reading and writing as powerful and irreplaceable skills for professional work. Regardless of their individual focuses, my courses emphasize the development of these skills—and they do so all the more forcefully when emerging AI technologies threaten to reduce students' intellectual capacities to the capacities of any given tool.

My teaching philosophy is thus organized into three main principles: (1) **the close is critical**; (2) **writing as an active learning method**; (3) **knowledge is always contingent**.

1) the close is critical:

In my courses, regardless of their format or focus, I teach close reading as an essential critical practice. Originating from literary studies, close reading is a particular kind of qualitative analysis that sustains attention on a very small selection of evidence, such as traditionally, a passage in a text. However, I find that close reading helps students not only to analyze evidence, like textual passages, depth, but also to generate new ways of using and interpreting all kinds of data.

For example, in my INFO 664: Programming Cultural Heritage course, I have students consider large datasets on an intimate scale, demonstrating how attention to detail can reveal new material for analysis and critique. In my INFO 664 class from last fall, I had several students develop projects which used Small Language Models (SLMs) to examine gender bias in popular culture,[1] to study discourses of toxic online spaces,[2] and to surface patterns in sensationalist language[3]—three projects which ended up winning the 2026 Info Show's "People's Choice Award."

[1] Jace Steiner, "Considering Transformers Models as a Tool for Character Analysis with Finn the Human." Fall 2025. `https://xxsteinxx.github.io/chara-analysis_at/`.

[2] Ellen Connors. "Machine Divinity." Fall 2025. `https://econn170.github.io/machine-divinity/index.html`

[3] Alana Maisel. "The New York Post's Environment and Wildlife." Fall 2025. `https://amaisel1.github.io/nypost-environment-and-wildlife/aboutproject.html`

2) writing as an active learning method:

Another technique that I often use in my courses is writing, both in low stakes, daily formats like freewriting exercises, and in long term assignments like formal papers. Writing is, in my experience, the most efficient method of active learning: it requires externalizing one's inner understanding in a coherent and material way, while also exposing it to alternative perspectives and real-world issues. For example, in my INFO: 656 Machine Learning course, the major assignment is a conference paper that students complete in groups and submit to a machine learning (ML) conference. This assignment not only keeps them up to date with recent advances in a rapidly changing field, it also encourages students to think deeply about their contributions to ML research, all while developing data science skills within a professionalizing context.

3) knowledge is always contingent:

One of the first lessons I learned in the classroom is the importance meeting students where they are, regardless of their previous training. One way of doing so is to invite students to use their lived experience as a ground for understanding and critique—to assure them that their own histories, combined with reflection, constitute a valuable kind of knowledge. A necessary corollary to knowledge as experience is to accept that there can be no single perspective for any question or issue. Rather than a single perspective, there are degrees of visibility made available through habit and privilege. In my teaching, I try to expand what is visible through the exposure to a wide range of theoretical points of view, particularly in the interdisciplinary selection of readings from my courses like INFO 601, INFO 656, and INFO 657. Readings in these courses explore fields such as Black Feminist Studies, Archival Studies, and AI Ethics research, showing differences in initial questions, assumptions, approaches, and their resulting conclusions.

Pratt SI Courses

The following are a list of courses that I have taught since beginning my position at Pratt in Fall 2024.

- INFO 656: Machine Learning, Fall 2026.
  - This course offers an introduction to machine learning as a practical tool that we can use, and as a technological field with social implications. We will learn about key concepts in machine learning; survey a few key machine learning techniques, such as supervised methods for machine learning (regression and classification), which attempt to map data onto desired outputs, and unsupervised methods (clustering and association), which attempt to find structure within data itself; use openly available tools to implement these techniques on text and image data; learn how to assess the effectiveness of different techniques on particular datasets; and discuss basic issues that confront all machine learning methods.
- INFO 657: Digital Humanities. Spring 2026.
  - This course examines the history, theory, and practice of digital humanities, paying special attention to the ways in which digital humanities are trans-

forming research, disciplines, and even the academy itself. Topics include contrasts and continuities between traditional and digital humanities; tools and techniques used by digital humanists; the processes of planning, funding, managing, and evaluating digital humanities projects; ways in which the digital humanities impact scholarly communication and higher education; and the special roles of libraries and information professionals in this growing movement.

- INFO 697: Special Topics - How to Build a Bot. Summer 2025.
  - This course offers a practical introduction to building bots in Python alongside a critical examination of algorithmic bias. Students will learn core programming skills like data collection and API interaction in order to create web crawlers and social media bots. In parallel, students will explore the ethical consequences of automated systems on social platforms, such as the amplification of misinformation and bias that perpetuate social inequalities and discrimination. This course will equip students with the critical perspectives and technical skills to analyze automated systems in a world increasingly shaped by AI and algorithmic decision-making. This course is intended for students interested in both technical development and the social impacts of automation.
- INFO 664: Programming Cultural Heritage. Fall 2024, Spring 2025, Fall 2025, Spring 2026, Fall 2026.
  - Technical knowledge and proficiency is an increasingly valued and useful skill in a cultural heritage information professional's skillset. This course will introduce and provide a platform for the building up of these abilities. Over the course of the semester the student will become familiar with programming, working with data in a programmatic manner and applying these skills to build a demonstrable project. This course will focus on teaching the basics that will enable an information professional to be successful in today's digital world.
- INFO 601: Foundations of Information. Fall 2024, Spring 2025, Fall 2025, Spring 2026, Fall 2026.
  - This foundational course focuses on the intersection of people, information, and technology and the theoretical and conceptual foundations of the information field. Students will be introduced to ideas and concepts that will inform future specializations in their course of study and provide them with concrete strategies for ongoing professional growth and development in their area of interest.

Mentoring & Advising

In addition to the 30 or so students that I teach directly each semester, I currently advise 35 students, mostly in Library and Information Science (LIS), but also in Data Analytics and Visualization (DAV), and Information Experience Design (IXD). Each semester, I meet individually with these students to discuss their progress in coursework and projects,

to strategize their final portfolios, and career expectations and goals.

I also advise two students groups: the *Stacks* Student Journal and Latines in Tech. The *Stacks* Student Journal is a new group founded by students from my INFO 601: Foundations of Information course. These students are in the process of producing their first issue of the *Stacks* journal, which will contain peer-reviewed versions of their 601 papers, showcasing the high level of critical work and writing accomplished in that course. The second group, Latines in Tech, is professional development group primarily focused on Latinx students. Their main goals are to provide professional development and networking opportunities for their members. Currently, I am working with that group to organize a community altar for to celebrate Dia De Los Muertos at the end of October.

Future Plans

My future plans involve developing the following:

- Most immediately, I hope to develop, in collaboration with my colleague Kathy Carbone, a study abroad program based in Lisbon, Portugal. The program will likely focus on an intersection of DH and archival work, though we are still in the early stages of discussing the possibilities.
- I also plan to develop a "Readings in Queer Studies" seminar style course. While I am aware that theoretically heavy courses have been less popular, I think students' appetite for theoretical material is growing. In courses like INFO: 601 Foundations of Information and INFO: 657 Digital Humanities, the assigned readings in Queer Studies generate much interest and discussion, especially among students in LIS, who often claim them as their favorite readings. For this course, I would complement the seminar focus with fieldwork activity that involves visiting queer archives in New York City.
- Finally, I plan to develop a Python programming course that is specific to working with text-based data. This course would build from my workshop that I run for the Data Storytelling Lab, which focuses on using advanced tools for text cleaning, processing, annotating, and NLP analysis. This course would join my other course, INFO 697: How to Build a Bot, to offer instruction in intermediate programming skills.